space where a blanket was set out on the grass. “Come, meet my wife and daughter.”

They walked toward a pretty dark-haired woman and a young girl with blonde hair tied in two braids.

“Léa, this is Virginie,” said Édouard, smiling between her and his wife.

“Thank you for coming to help today,” Virginie said. “Where are you from?”

“I live in Orléans in a boardinghouse with my sister, Rose.”

“Oh, yes, André’s friend,” she said, her eyes sparkling.

“And, this is our daughter, Paulette.” Édouard winked at the girl, who glanced up from her basket.

“How old are you?” Léa asked.

“Eight.” The girl grinned, showing a missing tooth.

“Paulette is a big help to me,” Virginie said, lifting a bottle and a loaf of cornbread from a small wicker basket, along with tin cups. Paulette, carrying tomatoes and radishes in her basket, spread them on the blanket. Léa eyed the bottle; whatever was inside smelled sweet, like grape juice.

At that moment, Rose and André walked round from the other side of the house, and introductions were again made by Édouard.

“Have either you or Rose had *bernache* before?” Virginie asked.

“No,” Rose said.

“I love it,” Paulette said, beaming.

“Be careful, *ma puce*. Don’t spill it all over you today like yesterday! It’s the fermented grape juice before it turns into wine. Full of vitamins.” Virginie poured a cup. “Here, have some. It’s refreshing after all of your hard work.”

The cool liquid on Léa’s throat was welcome. It tasted like apple juice. She couldn’t remember the last time she’d had fruit, maybe an apple in the spring. She looked at Rose to gauge her reaction.

“I can see why you love it, Paulette,” said Rose. “The taste is thrilling. Does it contain alcohol?”

Monsieur LeBlanc laughed. “About two percent. This morning, I drew it out of the vat, so it’s quite fresh. Enjoy.” He raised his glass, and they all toasted.

Though Léa’s shoulders throbbed from the lifting, she felt touched and grateful for their hospitality. Today was the first real lunch she and Rose